

SPORTS: IT'S NOT JUST CRICKET

Australia and India are partners in power

"Sydney Test reflected the contemporary India"

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Cricket tells us about the culture of a nation. So when we talk about the culture of India and Australia, it is not a false argument to say that it finds its expression on the cricket field too. The reverse also applies. Indian cricket reflects Indian culture which in turn tells us something about the Indian cricket team. What I am going to suggest to you is that Australian cricket culture has remained almost the same since Federation in 1901. But the Indian cricket culture has changed dramatically in the last five years to become much like Australian cricket culture. The reason goes back in history to 1850 in England, where there were two great forces vying for the dominance of the game—the professional cricketers and the upper classes. The victory was taken by the Lords, by the upper classes, who ran the game. This had a very significant effect on the game. The game became a means of instilling values in its players.

The phrase "it's not cricket" did not arise by accident. You don't hear "it's not soccer", you don't hear "it's not golf", you don't hear "it's not rugby", you hear "it's not cricket". Why? Because cricket uniquely was run by the upper classes and became a popular upper-class game. This had an immense effect on the history of the game in the colonies. Almost without exception the colonies accepted that upper-class British principle and played by that code. All the countries except one—Australia. Australia never accepted that English starting point, that the game was a way of instilling values. It was there to win or lose. Cricket is being played in the same hard, straightforward, unromantic, unsentimental way in Australia since Federation, probably before.

After Indian independence, we had generations and various movements

within India. The first major change was Gavaskar, who was the voice of protest, who said, "we're going to do it the Indian way." The next stage was the stage of Tendulkar, who is a great player and a great sportsman and comfortable with himself. The Sydney Test was the third and final stage of this development. Indian cricketers now come from the villages, the outstations. What happened in Sydney was an expression of that democratic Indian, confident, passionate, committed, fearless self. It was true independence of mind and economy.

What we have now in this world game is two forces who are rivals, but also partners. They don't know it yet, but they talk the same language. They come from the same places. What we have seen now is India becoming Australia. No one is really liking each other all that much but in the end their egalitarian side, the sense of justice in both countries will bind them together. Then it will be for the others to catch up.

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"THE SENSE OF JUSTICE IN INDIA AND AUSTRALIA WILL BIND BOTH THE COUNTRIES TOGETHER."

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